

The prophecy is parallel in thought to 8, 4, though, from its containing no allusion to hostilities with Judah, it may be inferred (Ew. Del. Ch. Kuen. Dillm.) that it was written before the Syro-Ephraimitish war had commenced.

17, 12-14. A short but singularly graphic prophecy, describing the ocean-like roar of the advancing Assyrian hosts, and their sudden dispersion.

In general conception (though the figures used are different) the prophecy resembles 14, 24-27, and may be assigned to the same period.

C. 18. On Ethiopia [Heb. Cush]. The king of Ethiopia, alarmed by intelligence of the approach of the Assyrians, is summoning his troops from different parts of his empire, *vv.* 1-2. Isaiah declares to him that his anxiety is needless: the plans of the Assyrians will be intercepted, and their hosts overthrown, independently of the arms of Ethiopia, *vv.* 3-6. Hereupon the Ethiopians will do homage to the God of Israel, *v.* 7.

The prophecy may be assigned, like the last, to the year 701. An advance upon Egypt lay always within the plans of the Assyrians: and the Ethiopians might well fear that Sennacherib, when he had conquered Judah and the Philistines, would pursue his successes, and make an endeavour to add not Egypt only, but Ethiopia as well, to his empire. In point of fact, Sennacherib was advancing towards Egypt when his army (at Pelusium) was smitten by a pestilence (*Hdt.* ii. 141; *Isaiah*, p. 81 f.).

C. 19. On Egypt. A period of unexampled collapse and decay, affecting every grade and class of society, is about to commence for Egypt, *vv.* 1-17, to be succeeded by the nation's conversion and spiritual renovation, *vv.* 18-25.

The prophecy is a remarkable one, both on account of its many allusions to the characteristic habits of the people and features of the country, and for the catholicity of the picture with which it closes (Assyria and Egypt, the one Judah's oppressor, the other its untrue friend, to be incorporated, on an equality with Israel itself, in the kingdom of God).

The date of the prophecy is not certain; but it is at least a plausible conjecture that it was written in 720 B.C., when Sargon defeated the Egyptians at Raphia. Sargon did not "rule over" Egypt (*v.* 4); but it is not necessary to suppose that Isaiah has here a definite person in view; he probably merely means to say that, in the political disorganization which he sees to be imminent, the country will fall a prey to the first ambitious and determined man who invades it. In point of fact, Sargon defeated the Egyptian arms both in 720 and in 711; Sennacherib did the same in 701; Esarhaddon penetrated into Egypt, and reduced it to the condition of an Assyrian province, c. 672; Psammetichus, a Libyan, made himself master of it shortly afterwards, c. 660, and revolutionized the policy of its former kings by opening it for the first time to the Greeks. Ew., Stade, Dillm., Kuen. (§ 43. 23-25) assign the prophecy to the period *after* Sennacherib's retreat in 701.

C. 20. On Ashdod. While Ashdod was besieged by the Assyrian troops in 711, Isaiah walks the street of Jerusalem in a captive's garb, continuing to do so for three years, in order to prefigure the shameful fate that would befall Egypt at the hands of the victorious Assyrians.

The date is fixed by Sargon's inscriptions, which allude to the siege of Ashdod, and imply that the revolt of the Philistines, which led to it, was carried through with promises of help from Egypt. Isaiah's symbolical act was doubtless meant indirectly as a protest against the Egyptianizing party in Jerusalem, and intended to impress forcibly upon the people of the capital the folly of reliance upon Egypt.

21, 1-10. On Babylon. The prophet in imagination sees Babylon besieged by an eager and impetuous foe, *vv.* 1-2: the vision agitates and appals him, *vv.* 3-4: the issue, for a while, appears uncertain, but in the end he is assured that the city has fallen, *vv.* 5-9; and he announces the result as a duty imposed upon him, but with no sense of satisfaction or relief, *v.* 10.

The prophecy has been commonly referred to the capture of Babylon by the Medes and Persians under Cyrus in 538 B.C. This view is open to two objections: (1) no intelligible purpose would be subserved by Isaiah's announcing to the generation of Hezekiah an occurrence lying nearly 200 years in the future, and *having no bearing on contemporary interests*; (2) it does not account for the alarm and aversion with which the prophet contemplates the issue (*vv.* 3, 4, 10), so different from the exultation displayed elsewhere by the prophets when announcing the fall of the great oppressing city (c. 13, 2-14, 23; c. 40-48; Jer. 50-51). The first of these objections would be obviated by the supposition that the prophecy is really the work of an author writing towards the close of the exile (Ew. Hitz. &c.); but even so the second would still retain its force. Hence the prophecy has been referred by Kleinert, *Stud. u. Krit.* 1877, p. 174 ff., Cheyne, and the present writer (*Isaiah*, p. 96 ff.) to a siege of Babylon by the *Assyrians* in Isaiah's own time. The inscriptions show that Merodach-Baladan made repeated efforts, in the time of Sargon and Sennacherib, to free Babylon from the Assyrian yoke, and that the Assyrians on three separate occasions, B.C. 710, 703, and 696, besieged and entered the rebellious city. As Merodach-Baladan had probably (c. 39) some understanding with Hezekiah, the struggle between him and the Assyrians would be watched with interest in Judah: the success of the latter would mean the punishment of those suspected of being implicated with him. This success (perhaps in 710) Isaiah finds it his duty to announce. His human sympathies are with his own people: he foresees the sufferings which the present triumph of Assyria will entail upon them ("my threshing," &c. *v.* 10); and hence the distress with which the prospect fills him (*v.* 3 f.), and the apparent unwillingness with which he delivers his message. This view of the prophecy has not, however, found favour with recent writers on Isaiah (Delitzsch; Kuen. § 43. 10; Dillm.),

who agree in supposing it to refer to the conquest of Babylon by Cyrus, and ascribe it accordingly to a prophet living towards the close of the exile.

21, 11-12. On Dumah (*i.e.* Edom). A call of inquiry reaches the prophet from Seir (Gen. 36, 8 f.): he replies, in dark and enigmatic terms, that though the "morning" (*i.e.* brighter days) may dawn for Edom, it will quickly be followed by a "night" of trouble; for the present no more favourable answer can be given.

21, 13-17. On 'Arāb. A tide of invasion is about to overflow the region inhabited by 'Arāb and Kedar (*v.* 17); the Dedanite caravans passing through it have to seek refuge in the woods: the people of Têma bring supplies to the fugitive traders. Within a year Kedar will be so reduced in numbers, that only an insignificant remnant will survive.

'Arāb denotes not Arabia (in our sense of the word), but a particular nomad tribe inhabiting the N. of the Peninsula, and mentioned Ez. 27, 20 f., with Dedan and Kedar, as engaged in commerce with Tyre. Kedar was a wealthy pastoral tribe, 60, 7. Jer. 49, 29. Têma lay some 250 miles S.-E. of Edom. Sargon's troops were engaged in war with the Philistines in both 720 and 711: and it may be conjectured that these two prophecies were delivered in view of an expected campaign of the Assyrians in the neighbouring regions in one of these years.

22, 1-14. A rebuke, addressed by Isaiah to the inhabitants of the capital, on account of the undignified temper displayed by them when their city was threatened with an assault by the foe. *V.* 1 describes the demeanour of the people; *vv.* 2-3 the events which had preceded; *vv.* 4-5 the grief and shame overwhelming the prophet in consequence; *vv.* 6-12 the hasty measures of defence which had been taken by the people, and the inappropriate temper manifested by them at the time and subsequently: *v.* 13 is the prophet's rebuke.

The prophecy belongs probably to either 711 or 701 B.C. In 711 B.C. Sargon's troops were in the neighbourhood of Judah (engaged upon the siege of Ashdod); and as Judah is mentioned at the same time as "speaking treason" against him, it is possible that some collision may have taken place with Sargon's soldiers, resulting in a panic and defeat, such as Isaiah describes.¹ The objection to referring it to 701, the year of Sennacherib's invasion, is its minatory tone; for in the other prophecies belonging undoubtedly to this period, Isaiah makes it his aim to encourage and sustain

¹ But the hypothesis that Sargon gained a series of successes, and even ended by capturing Jerusalem, lacks adequate historical foundation, and must be rejected (see W. R. Smith, *Proph.* p. 295 ff.; *Isaiah*, p. 101 f.; Schrader, *KAT.* p. 407 f.; Kuen. § 41. 4c; Dillm. pp. 3, 103, 197).

his people: but this difficulty may be overcome by referring it to an *episode* in this invasion—by supposing it to allude, for instance, to a panic occasioned by the first conflict with the Assyrians (W. R. Smith, *Proph.* p. 346; Dillm.), or else to have been spoken by the prophet *after* Sennacherib's retreat, in condemnation of the temper shown by the people while the invasion was in progress (Guthe, Sörensen, Kuenen, § 43. 19-21).

22, 15-25. On Shebna. Shebna, a minister holding in Jerusalem the influential office of Governor or Comptroller of the Palace, is threatened by Isaiah with disgrace and banishment; and Eliakim, a man of approved views, is nominated as his successor.

It is evident that Shebna represented a policy obnoxious to Isaiah—probably he was one of the friends of Egypt. The prophecy must date from before 701; for in that year (36, 3. 37, 2) Eliakim is mentioned as holding the office here promised him by Isaiah, and Shebna occupies the subordinate position of "Scribe," or secretary.

C. 23. On Tyre. In picturesque and effective imagery, the approaching fall of Tyre, the great commercial and colonizing city of antiquity, is described, *vv.* 1-14. After seventy years of enforced quiescence, however, Tyre will revive, and resume her former occupation; but her gains, instead of being applied to her own profit or adornment, will be consecrated to the service of Jehovah, *vv.* 15-18.

Isaiah expresses here, in a form consonant with the special character of Tyre—as before, in the case of Ethiopia, 18, 7, and Egypt, 19, 18 ff.—the thought of its future acknowledgment of the true God: the commercial spirit, by which it is actuated, will not be discarded, but it will be elevated and ennobled.

The date of the prophecy depends partly upon *v.* 13. This verse is difficult and uncertain: but if the rendering of RV. be correct, the prophet points, as a warning to Tyre, to the punishment recently inflicted upon Chaldæa by the Assyrians—probably in 710-09 or 703 (p. 195); and the prophecy will have been written shortly before Sennacherib's invasion of Phœnicia in 701 (Cheyne, W. R. Smith, *Proph.* p. 333; cf. *Isaiah*, p. 106). But the "Chaldæans" are introduced somewhat unexpectedly; and Del. (whose rendering of the received text is too forced to be probable) inclines to adopt the emendation of Ew. and Schrader (*KAT.* p. 409 f.) כנענים *Canaanites* for כשדים, the verse then referring, of course, to the fate impending on Phœnicia itself. Kuenen (§ 42. 23), finding this verse inexplicable, disregards it, and assigns the prophecy to the period of Shalmaneser's siege of Tyre (between 727 and 723 B.C.), related by Josephus (*Arch.* ix. 14. 2).

III. C. 24-27. These chapters are intimately connected